

The Complete CSCS Exam Prep Checklist

A step-by-step companion to structure your preparation - from your first study session to exam day. Print it, tick it, and walk into the exam with total confidence.

KNOW THE EXAM BEFORE YOU START

- **Section 1 - Scientific Foundations:** 1.5 hours. 80 scored plus 15 pretest multiple-choice questions covering exercise sciences, exercise physiology, and nutrition.
- **Section 2 - Practical/Applied:** 2.5 hours. 110 scored plus 15 pretest multiple-choice questions covering exercise technique, program design, organization/administration, and testing/evaluation - including video-supported technique items.
- **Eligibility:** The NSCA requires academic and practical experience credentials (typically a bachelor's degree in a related field). Confirm yours before registering.
- **Scope:** This checklist follows the domains of the NSCA Exam Content Outline (ECO) so nothing on the exam catches you by surprise.

PHASE 1 - SET UP FOR SUCCESS

- ☐ Confirm your NSCA eligibility and register for the exam. Picking a target exam date is the single best way to create urgency and structure.
- ☐ Download the official NSCA Exam Content Outline (ECO) and keep it visible while you study - every session should map to a domain.
- ☐ Build a realistic weekly study schedule. Most successful candidates prepare consistently for 8 to 12 weeks.
- ☐ Enroll in a structured prep course so every study session has expert guidance instead of guesswork.
- ☐ Gather your study materials: the textbook, your notes, and one trusted practice question bank.
- ☐ Take a baseline practice test to identify your strongest and weakest domains before you start.
- ☐ Set up a distraction-free study space and block fixed study times in your calendar.
- ☐ Join a study community or recruit an accountability partner who is preparing for the same exam.

PHASE 2 - MASTER THE CONTENT, CHAPTER BY CHAPTER

Your per-chapter routine: watch the lecture, take the domain quiz, log every mistake, and re-test yourself after 48 hours. Tick a chapter only when you can explain its key concepts out loud.

Module A - Scientific Foundations (Chapters 1-12)

- ☐ Ch. 1: Structure and Function of Body Systems
- ☐ Ch. 2: Biomechanics of Resistance Exercise
- ☐ Ch. 3: Bioenergetics of Exercise and Training
- ☐ Ch. 4: Endocrine Responses to Resistance Exercise
- ☐ Ch. 5: Adaptations to Anaerobic Training
- ☐ Ch. 6: Adaptations to Aerobic Training
- ☐ Ch. 7: Age-Related Differences
- ☐ Ch. 8: Sex-Related Differences
- ☐ Ch. 9: Psychological Foundations of Performance
- ☐ Ch. 10: Basic Nutritional Factors
- ☐ Ch. 11: Nutrition Strategies for Performance
- ☐ Ch. 12: Performance-Enhancing Substances

Module B - Exercise Technique (Chapters 15-17)

- ☐ Ch. 15: Performance Preparation, Mobility, and Flexibility
- ☐ Ch. 16: Exercise Technique - Free Weights and Machines
- ☐ Ch. 17: Exercise Technique - Alternative Modes

Module C - Program Design (Chapters 18-22)

- ☐ Ch. 18: Program Design for Resistance Training
- ☐ Ch. 19: Plyometric Training
- ☐ Ch. 20: Speed and Agility Training
- ☐ Ch. 21: Aerobic Endurance and Metabolic Training
- ☐ Ch. 22: Periodization

Module D - Organization & Administration (Chapters 23-26)

- ☐ Ch. 23: Rehabilitation, Reconditioning, and Medical Issues
- ☐ Ch. 24: Overreaching, Overtraining, and Recovery
- ☐ Ch. 25: Facility Design, Layout, and Organization
- ☐ Ch. 26: Facility Policies, Procedures, and Legal Issues

Module E - Testing & Evaluation (Chapters 13-14)

- ☐ Ch. 13: Principles of Test Selection and Administration
- ☐ Ch. 14: Administration, Scoring, and Interpretation of Tests

Milestone: all 26 chapters ticked. Move on to timed practice only when every module quiz sits at 80% or higher.

PHASE 3 - PRACTICE & ASSESS

- ☐ Complete the domain-specific quiz after finishing every chapter - do not move on until you score 80% or higher.
- ☐ Work through 150+ practice questions spread across all exam domains, not just your favorites.
- ☐ Simulate exam pace: roughly 55 seconds per question in Section 1 and 70 seconds per question in Section 2.
- ☐ Drill athlete case-study scenarios using a systematic needs-analysis framework.
- ☐ Drill research case-study scenarios - practice interpreting study designs and statistics.
- ☐ Practice video-based technique analysis: watch the entire clip before choosing your answer.
- ☐ Keep an error log. Revisit every missed question within 48 hours.
- ☐ Take a full-length mock exam two weeks out, and a second one one week out.

PHASE 4 - FINAL WEEK & EXAM DAY

- ☐ Final week: light review of your error log and weak domains only - no new material in the last 48 hours.
- ☐ Confirm your exam appointment, location, and required ID at least three days ahead.
- ☐ Plan your route and aim to arrive 30 minutes early.
- ☐ Sleep 7 to 8 hours the night before. Do not cram past midnight.
- ☐ Eat a familiar, balanced meal before the exam - nothing new on exam day.
- ☐ Read every question completely. Watch for words like NOT, EXCEPT, and BEST.
- ☐ Budget your time per section and flag hard questions so you can return to them later.
- ☐ For video-based items, watch the entire clip before answering.
- ☐ Never leave a question blank - an educated guess beats an empty box.
- ☐ Stay calm and trust your preparation. You have done the work.

NEED MORE STRUCTURE?

The KINÉTIKA CSCS Prep Course gives you 30+ hours of chapter-by-chapter video lectures, 150+ practice questions, domain-aligned quizzes for every chapter, and proven case-study frameworks - with lifetime access and free updates.

Enroll on our website and turn this checklist into a done-for-you study plan.

KINÉTIKA is an independent prep resource and is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or sponsored by the NSCA. This checklist is aligned with the domains of the NSCA Exam Content Outline (ECO) and is intended for personal study planning.